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362 DEAD, 1,400 MISSING IN DEADLY FLOOD

Second flood warning amid rescue operations along Nepal-Tibet border

DUBAI

BY STEPHEN N. R.

Senior Associate Editor

A massive glacier collapse high in the Himalayas unleashed the wall of water, ice and debris that devastated communities along the Nepal-Tibet border, killing at least 362 people and leaving more than 1,400 missing, scientists and authorities said yesterday.

The US Geological Survey said what was initially reported as a magnitude 4.4 earthquake was actually seismic activity generated by a glacial collapse and debris flow.

The collapse sent a torrent downstream with “catastrophic” consequences, sweeping away villages, bridges, buildings and vehicles as it surged deep into Nepal.

Massive deployment

Rescuers waded through thick mud and used sniffer dogs, drones and boats as the massive search entered a second day.

Nepal deployed 9,260 police, soldiers and armed police personnel, while nearly 800 emergency workers were mobilised on the Tibetan side. Nepali police said 359 bodies had been recovered, while three deaths were reported in Tibet.

In Nepal, 910 people remained out of contact, including 517 foreign tourists. Another 558 people were missing in Tibet, including 260 foreigners.

Missing tourists, pilgrims

Many of those missing are foreign tourists and Hindu pil-



AFP

■ Houses lie deluged in sludge after flash floods at Devighat, Bidur Municipality in Nepal's Nuwakot district yesterday.

grims travelling to or returning from Mount Kailash. The nationalities include Indians and people from Australia, Britain, Malaysia, the Netherlands, Portugal, South Africa, South Korea and the United States.

One tour group of 20 sent its last video just nine minutes before the flood struck. Noth-

ing has been heard from them since.

‘Inland tsunami’

The torrent has been described as an “inland tsunami”, travelling nearly 170km south into Nepal. Rasuwa, near the border, was hit first, but bodies have been recovered as far

south as Chitwan near India. Authorities are now warning of another danger. Satellite information indicates debris have blocked the Bhote Koshi river near the disaster zone, creating a growing lake that could burst and unleash a second flood.

Residents and rescue teams downstream have been urged

to stay away from riverbanks. International assistance is also arriving. India has flown in nearly 50 tonnes of supplies and is sending Bailey bridges, while UN agencies, the Red Cross, Japan, Switzerland and the United States have announced emergency assistance.

SEE ALSO P10

Gargash: Credible media vital to protect truth from misinformation

UAE official says media plays key role during periods of heightened regional tension

DUBAI

Gulf News Report

● **Qatar and Iran ministers yesterday discussed de-escalation efforts and the proposed Iran-Oman framework for Hormuz.**

Credible and balanced media coverage is essential to protecting the truth from misinformation at a sensitive time for the region, Dr Anwar Gargash, Diplomatic Adviser to the UAE President, said yesterday.

In a post on X, Gargash said the media was a key instrument during periods of heightened regional tension and that competing narratives formed part of the balance of conflict.

“Media is a key instrument in the sensitive circumstances the region is going through, and the narrative is part of the balance of conflict,” Gargash said.

Accurate and fair media

“Credibility and balance therefore remain a professional and ethical necessity, without naivety or equating parties that do not abide by the same rules. What is required is accurate and fair media that understands the

environment of confrontation, protects the truth from misinformation and manipulation, and safeguards public awareness,” he added.

His comments came as the US-Iran war approaches its six-month mark today, with regional diplomatic efforts continuing to end the conflict and find a way forward over the Strait of Hormuz.

Qatar’s Prime Minister and Foreign Minister Sheikh Mohammed Bin Abdulrahman Al Thani met Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi in Tehran yesterday, following recent visits by Oman’s top diplomat and senior Pakistani officials.

US President Donald Trump, however, told Al Jazeera he had “no time schedule” for resolving the conflict, saying he believed the US was “winning very big”.

Qatar said the ministers discussed de-escalation efforts and the proposed Iran-Oman framework for Hormuz. Al Thani stressed the need to respect the sovereignty of neighbouring states, guarantee freedom of navigation and pursue dialogue.

Temporary shipping corridor

Iran and Oman have been discussing a framework for a temporary shipping corridor through Hormuz. Tehran, however, says the waterway will not fully reopen unless Washington meets demands including lifting its naval blockade, unfreezing Iranian assets and removing oil sanctions.

The pressure is increasingly being felt inside Iran. Vice-President Mohammad Jafar Ghaempanah said the US naval blockade was preventing Tehran from importing enough petrol to make up for a domestic production shortfall, with queues reported at filling stations.

Separately, Norway-based Iran Human Rights said Iran had executed at least 511 people so far this year, including 29 linked to January’s anti-government protests.

SEE ALSO P8-9

Dubai’s shared housing law with up to Dh1m fines in force

Illegal shared housing targeted; permits required for properties, operators

DUBAI

BY SAJALA SASEENDRAN

Chief Reporter

Dubai’s new shared housing law is now in force, and thousands of tenants across the emirate are asking the same question: does this mean the knock on the door starts now?

The new law regulates shared housing in Dubai, safeguarding the rights of owners and residents, ensuring safe and healthy living conditions, preventing overcrowding and informal housing, addressing building and land use violations and promoting fair rentals.

What is different now is inspections specifically to enforce Law No. (4) of 2026, which regulates the occupancy and management of shared housing, by checking for valid shared housing permits, registered contracts and compliance with the categories and standards this law sets out.

Every owner, operator and

company currently running shared housing has been handed a one-year grace period from August 26, 2026, to bring their units in line with the new rules. Dubai Municipality said the grace period itself “serves as a warning and regulatory period before the application of penalties begins.”

Eviction is possible under the law, but it is neither automatic nor immediate. Properties that fall foul of permit rules can be vacated following a decision by an execution judge, and authorities can suspend an operator for up to six months, cancel permits, coordinate the cancellation of a trade licence, cut utilities, or refuse to register a tenancy contract for a non-compliant unit.

A suspended operator or a cancelled permit does not evict tenants overnight. The law allows authorities to let occupants stay on for a specified period and gives them “sufficient time” to find alternative accommodation. Once enforcement does begin, penalties range from Dh500 to Dh500,000 per violation. Repeat the same offence within a year, and the fine can go up to Dh1 million.

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